

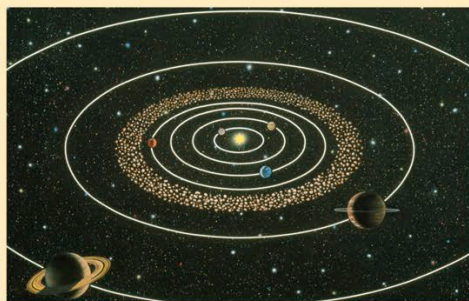
The asteroid belt

Asteroids are chunks of rock. Some are small enough to hold in your hand, while others are larger than a mountain. Most asteroids in our solar system orbit the Sun within the asteroid belt, which lies between Jupiter and Mars.

Leftovers

Scientists believe that asteroids are the bits and pieces left over after the formation of the solar system.

Asteroids can be pulled in by the gravity of nearby planets to become moons.



Most asteroids exist in the asteroid belt, of which about 400,000 have been identified. It takes between three and six years for asteroids to orbit the Sun.

Hurry across!

Despite the existence of millions of asteroids in the belt, spacecraft such as Galileo (right), have crossed this area of space without colliding with a single one. That's because most of the asteroids are thousands of kilometres (miles) apart.

